I discovered that NBA home teams win most of their games, but this percentage has been declining over the years. What factors could account for this trend?

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Several factors may explain the long-term decline in NBA home-court advantage, though the evidence is stronger for some than others:

1. **The rise of three-point shooting.**
   A major study of 32 NBA seasons found that teams increasingly relied on three-point shots while making fewer two-point shots and free throws. Because three-point shooting is less dependent on drives, contested shots, and foul calls near the basket, it may reduce the ways that playing at home benefits a team. The researchers concluded that this change in shot selection partially explains the decline in home advantage journals.plos.org.
2. **Fewer free-throw opportunities and possibly less referee influence.**
   Home teams historically attempted more free throws than visiting teams. If modern offenses involve fewer drives and post-ups, there are fewer opportunities for crowd-influenced foul calls to affect the game. However, the study did not directly establish referee bias as the cause uwm.edu +1 .
3. **Changes in the home crowd and arena environment.**
   Crowd noise, familiarity with the arena, and psychological support may contribute to home advantage. Over time, audiences may have become less locally concentrated or less influential. This is a plausible explanation, but attendance alone did not improve the study's ability to predict home advantage journals.plos.org.
4. **Improved travel, scheduling, and player preparation.**
   Better transportation, recovery practices, sports medicine, and reduced travel fatigue could make road games less difficult. Rest between games and back-to-back scheduling are also potential contributors. The cited neural-network study did not directly test these factors, so their importance remains uncertain journals.plos.org.
5. **Rule and technology changes.**
   Instant replay, greater officiating oversight, and changes in league rules may have reduced any persistent home-team advantage from close officiating decisions. This has been proposed in earlier research, but the provided evidence does not demonstrate how much of the decline it explains journals.plos.org.
6. **The changing competitive and strategic environment.**
   Teams now use more analytics, standardized training, advanced scouting, and efficient offensive systems. These developments may make teams better equipped to perform away from home. Increased three-point shooting also raises the role of shooting variance, which can make individual road wins more attainable.

Overall, the best-supported explanation in the provided research is the **league-wide shift from two-point and free-throw-oriented offense toward three-point shooting**. Other factors—crowd effects, officiating, travel, rest, and rule changes—may contribute, but the evidence does not establish them as the primary cause uwm.edu +1 . Correlation should also be interpreted cautiously: the study identifies an association between changing shot selection and declining home advantage, not definitive proof that one caused the other.

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